Khrushchev and sent him into retirement. It would be only later that Leonid Brezhnev ridiculed Khrushchev for declaring at the Presidium meeting: “We can hit a fly in Washington with our missiles!” For now, he was silent. Khrushchev’s aides, probably with the sole exception of Mikoyan, were there either to approve and endorse Khrushchev’s decisions or to remain silent. Khrushchev called in his peers not to seek their opinions and collectively formulate a policy but to get their approval and thereby legitimize his actions in case things went wrong. And at this point they were truly going wrong.

Khrushchev’s goal was to sell his colleagues-turned-clients another abrupt turn of his policy. The previous day he had convinced them to add the missiles in Turkey to his offer to Kennedy; now he wanted them to agree to remove that element. He began with an appeal to party history, recalling Lenin’s tactics during the revolution and civil war: “There was a time when we advanced, as in October 1917. But in March 1918 we had to retreat, having signed the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk with Germany. That decision was dictated by our interests: we had to save Soviet rule. Now we find ourselves face to face with the threat of war and nuclear catastrophe, as a result of which human civilization may perish. To save humanity, we should retreat.” To hear Khrushchev tell it, he was now saving not only Soviet rule but humankind as a whole.[13]

“I have called you all together to take counsel and consider whether you agree with such a decision,” said Khrushchev, concluding his opening remarks. The “decision” was already there: he was simply asking for approval. He had a two-pronged strategy: “If an attack is provoked, we have issued an order to inflict a retaliatory strike.” Then came his “peace” proposal. “We agree to dismantle the missile installations,” he said, according to the terse protocol of the meeting. No dissent was recorded. Troianovsky recalled Gromyko and Mikoyan expressing their opinions: since neither was a hawk, they probably approved Khrushchev’s de facto decision. With the rest remaining silent and taking the attitude “Whatever you say,” Khrushchev got his authorization.[14]

It was in the middle of the discussion of Khrushchev’s proposal that Troianovsky interrupted the meeting: he had an urgent message for the Presidium. “During the session I was called to the telephone. Vladimir